

Tam orada, Camlaca yokunda
 Bir kış bulut çekelim gökyüzünden
 Damarlarımızın gıcırdağına
 Bir kış defa kış, von bir defa gel

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WHERE I'M COMING FROM

I am so glad that you are here. This workbook holds reflections that I hope yield transformation for you. The words written in this book are born from my own lived experience, and my conviction that your undergrad years are pivotal.

I spent four years at a wonderful bible college where I created friends who became family, learned from professors who were deep wells of wisdom, and where my every day was immersed in rhythms that pointed me to Christ.

But as I've been out of that environment for about a decade now, and launched into my life of being a wife, mom and working in the corporate world, I've realized that existing in a spiritual setting does not automatically make you mature.

Did you catch that? Existing in a spiritual setting does not automatically make you spiritually (emotionally, mentally...) mature. I believe wholeheartedly that being in an environment like I was with bible college is a gift of mercy from God. It is good and wise to live intentionally among Christians and to permeate your life with godly rhythms.

The issue that can come in, however, is it can be easy to not take full accountability of your personal spiritual growth and maybe more than that, your growth in the art of living wisely. Living wisely necessitates knowing who you uniquely are, where you are going in life and discerning the decisions that will either get you closer to that place or cause you to drift.

I hope this workbook is an aid for you as you seek to live wisely. I hope that as you engage with the reflections, you begin to see with sharper vision who God created you to be, to honestly analyze who you are now in your daily rhythms and habits, and how your decisions now are impacting your future.

HOLDING EXCITEMENT AND WORRY

Depending on where you are at in your academic journey, you may not be new to the excitement and challenges that your university environment brings. You might be over the jitters of launching out of the house and living apart from your family. And maybe, hopefully, you are thriving in the world you now occupy. Conversely, maybe this is new to you and those jitters are ever present. I am so glad that you are taking the time to reflect that you are beginning (or continuing) your college journey intentionally.

And possibly at this point, new anxieties have arisen. Am I where I should be by now? Am I headed in the direction I want? Does God actually have a purpose for me? Why do I feel so awkward around my peers when everyone else seems so confident?

Maybe you see yourself in one of those thoughts, or maybe it's something else for you. Either way, I encourage you to engage with this workbook honestly and take ownership of what it brings up for you. My hope is that it's something transformational.

A handwritten signature in black ink. It begins with a simple heart symbol, followed by the name "Rachel" written in a cursive, flowing script.

PART 1: ROOT

IDENTITY IN CHRIST

God cares about the outworking of your life. What do I mean by that? I mean that all the elements that make up your day to day matter to Him. Your eventual career, your choice in a life partner, the hobbies you invest your time in, they all matter to God.

And it's very possible that you could be living a life that, on paper, looks like a life that would be pleasing to God. But anything can become a distraction or hindrance from keeping our gaze on God. And in order to most clearly see ourselves, our gaze needs to be fixed on Him.

This section will offer you the opportunity to reflect on how you see yourself as you gaze on your Creator. It will prompt you to honestly examine where your roots may not be deep and how you might further fix your gaze on Christ in those areas.

A little note of encouragement, don't compare yourself to others as you reflect here. You are unique and God's purposes in you will look different than anyone else. It may not be what you expected, but as you look to Christ and seek after Him, you will be better able to walk in that path He has set for you.

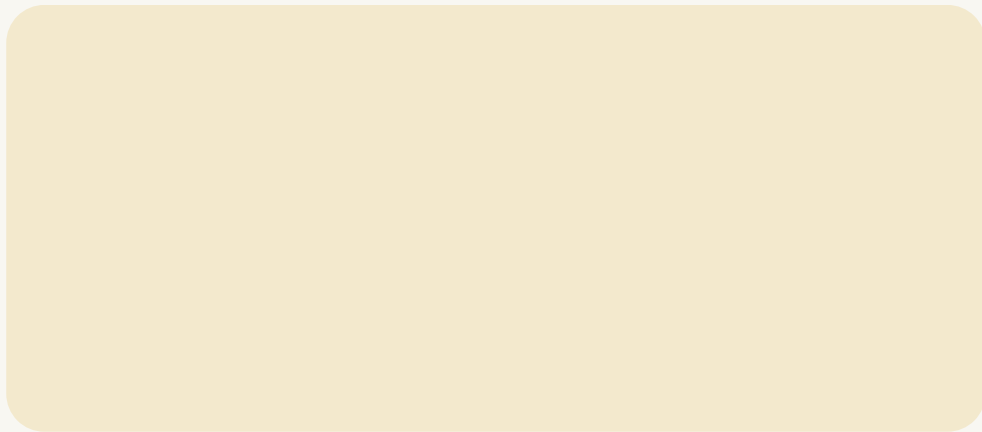
Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith.

Hebrews 12:1-2

REFLECTIONS

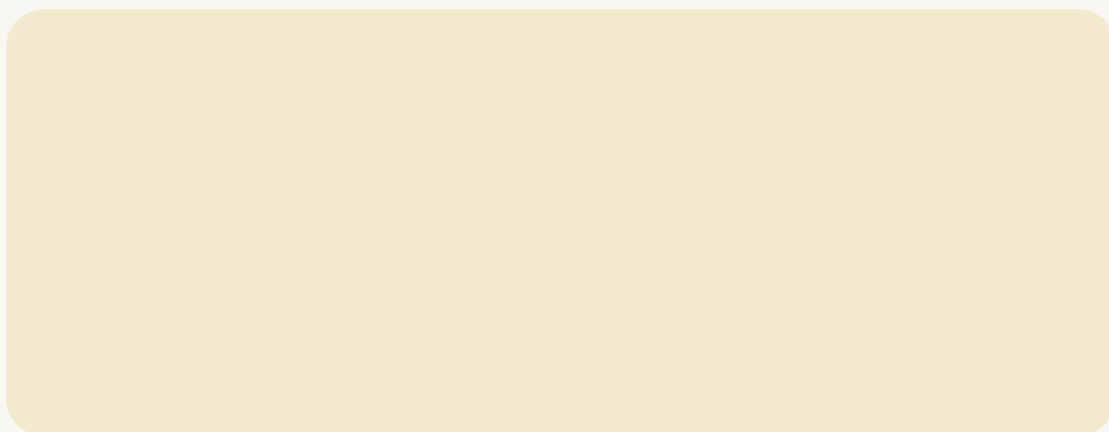
REFLECTION 1.

Examine where you see deep roots in your life. These are roots you can attribute to having your gaze fixed on Christ in a particular way. To help with this reflection, think about where you notice fruit in your life, what trusted friends have shared with you about what they see in you, or what makes you feel alive and energized.



REFLECTION 2.

Prayerfully examine where in your life roots may not be deep. Indicators could be ways in which you don't feel confident, where you notice anxiety or fear run the show, or it could be an area of persistent sin or struggle. Please note, this section is not meant to usher you into a place of self-condemnation. It's meant to invite a time of honestly reflecting on areas in your life where you are out of alignment with who you want to be.



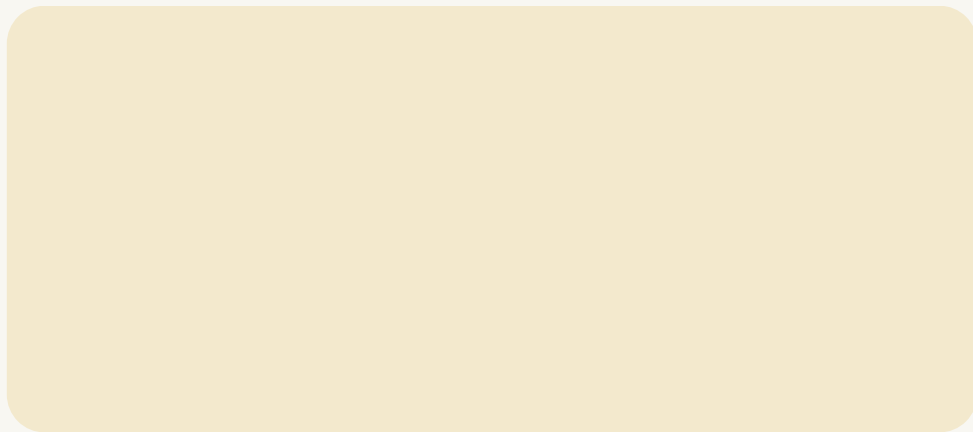
EMBRACE AND RELEASE

At this point, you have reflected on where your roots are flourishing and where they are being quenched. As you think about where you are flourishing with deep roots, be sure to clarify what those specific roots are. It could be you have deep trust in God to provide or you joyfully sacrifice your time and energy for others.

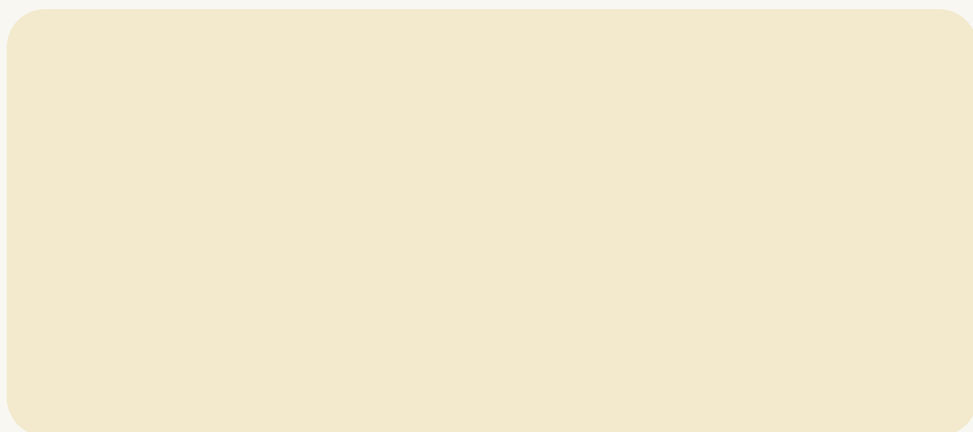
And on the other hand, you will have reflected on where you do not feel anchored. It could be you find yourself constantly comparing yourself to others, or you find yourself wanting to be entertained and distracted most of the time.

Whatever came up for you, take some time to name what you want to release as you go forward. This will relate to what came up for you with those shallower roots. Then you will name what you want to embrace. This will relate to what came up for you as you reflected on where your roots run deep.

I'M EMBRACING....



I'M RELEASING...



PART 2: REALIGN CHOICES AND VALUES

Maybe you have done work around your values already, it can be a popular activity in the workplace and even in education to help people make informed decisions. I want to take it a bit deeper here.

As you think about what you value, are you happy with what you see? I'm not talking about what you say you value, but what your actions and thoughts show that you value. More than a feeling, what you value will come through in what you think about, how you spend your time and how you interact with others. I know for myself, I need to regularly look at my life and analyze if I'm aligned with my stated values. If not, I need to know why there's been a shift.

We are not exempt from drifting into patterns that are out of whack with the person we know we want to be simply because we are Christians. Embodied values are the product of daily choices. So what choices are you making? Do you feel like you have the discernment to judge between right and wrong or to hear what God is saying?

The good news is that God doesn't play hide-and-seek. Seek Him and ask for wisdom within your decision-making, that they would align with the values you have.

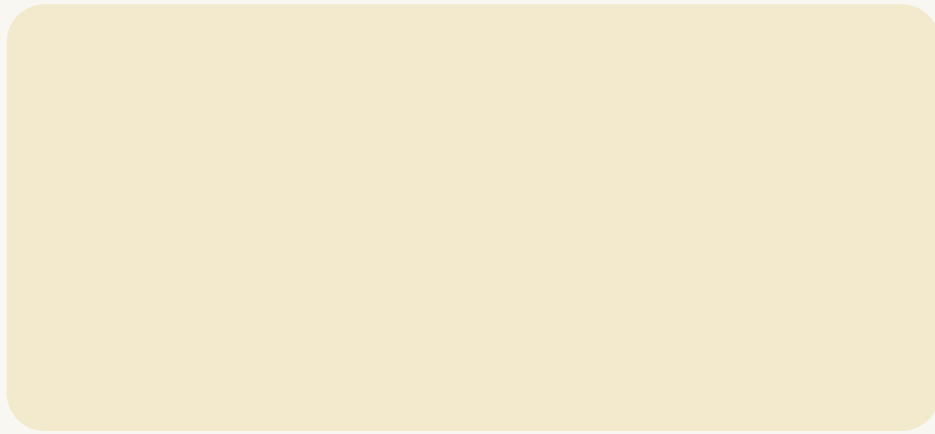
Just because something is a value doesn't mean making decision-aligned values is easy.

"People do not drift toward Holiness. Apart from grace-driven effort, people do not gravitate toward godliness, prayer, obedience to Scripture, faith, and delight in the Lord. We drift toward compromise and call it tolerance; we drift toward disobedience and call it freedom; we drift toward superstition and call it faith. We cherish the indiscipline of lost self-control and call it relaxation; we slouch toward prayerlessness and delude ourselves into thinking we have escaped legalism; we slide toward godlessness and convince ourselves we have been liberated."

D.A. Carson

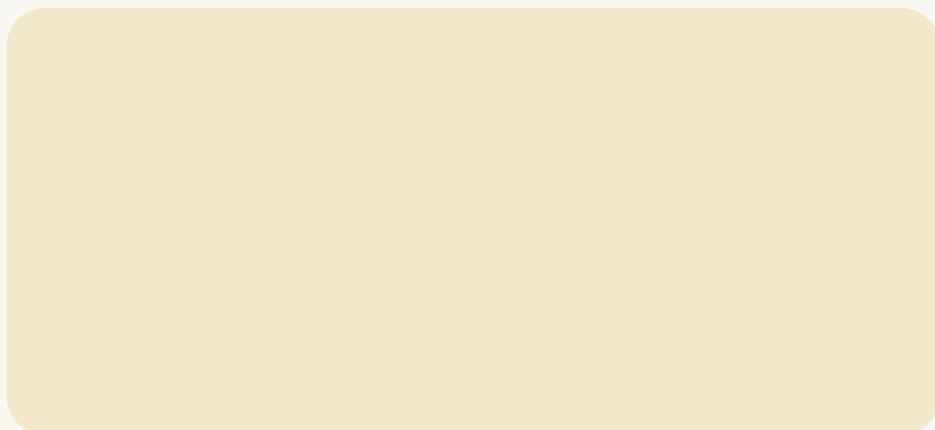
REFLECTION 1.

Take a few moments to take stock of the major areas in your life– how you interact with friends and family, what you dwell on mentally, how you steward your body, your attitude when serving, just to name a few. Ask God to graciously show you where your life doesn't align with what you say you value. Then honestly examine why that is. Perhaps you slander someone to your friends consistently even though you say you value honoring God with your tongue. Again, we are not entering into self-condemnation here. The beauty of the gospel is that when we look at our sin, we have a place to take it, and that is to the cross where we are met with love. Every time the Spirit reveals more of my sin to me, and I take it to Jesus with repentance, I learn more of His love. When I see my sin and I let shame overwhelm me, though, I create a chasm between myself and the love Jesus desires to show me. So, take a few moments to reflect and write below.



REFLECTION 2.

Sit with the D.A. Carson quote above. He talks about the things that people naturally drift toward– compromise, disobedience, prayerlessness etc. Which area might you see yourself in when you are in a place of drifting? Maybe what you drift into isn't on his list, but take a moment to consider where you tend to drift when you aren't pursuing holiness?



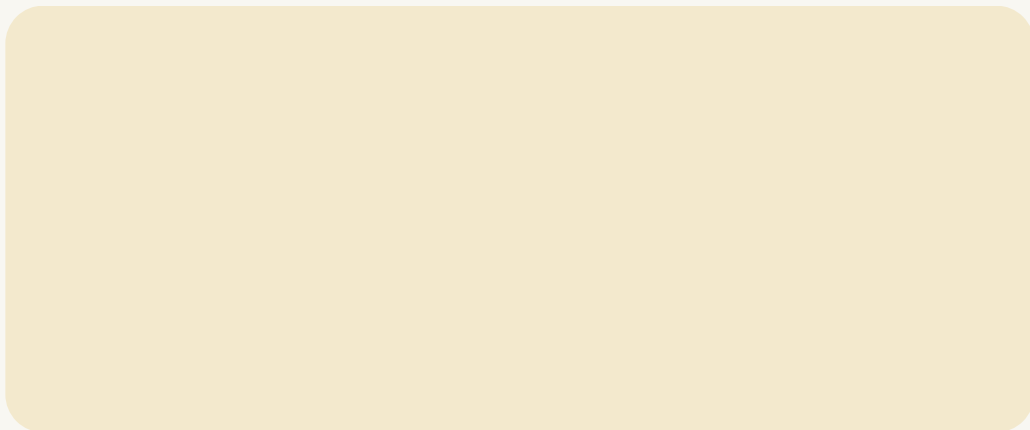
EMBRACE AND RELEASE

This section had some heavy reflecting. You honestly looked at your life and analyzed where you may be living out of sync with your values and where you tend to drift. I can't emphasize enough how important that work is. It is so easy to analyze our lives by how we feel, by measuring ourselves against others, or simply neglecting to do the work of noticing.

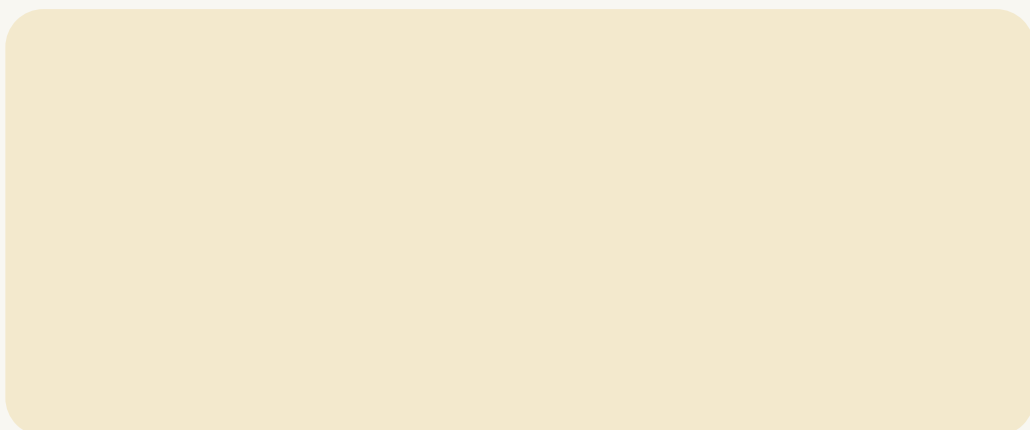
This embrace and release you're about to do is important, and I encourage you to perhaps take what you write here and put it on sticky notes where you'll see it. It's so easy to fall back into old habits when we get busy, distracted, tired or even apathetic.

So in the spaces below, reflect on what came up for you that you'd like to embrace. Maybe you sensed there is a particular area in your life where you want to get more aligned with your values on, write that below! And as you think about what you are releasing, think back to the tendencies to drift or the habits that you want to rid yourself of and write them below

I'M EMBRACING....



I'M RELEASING...



PART 3: RISE

CONFIDENCE AND PURPOSE

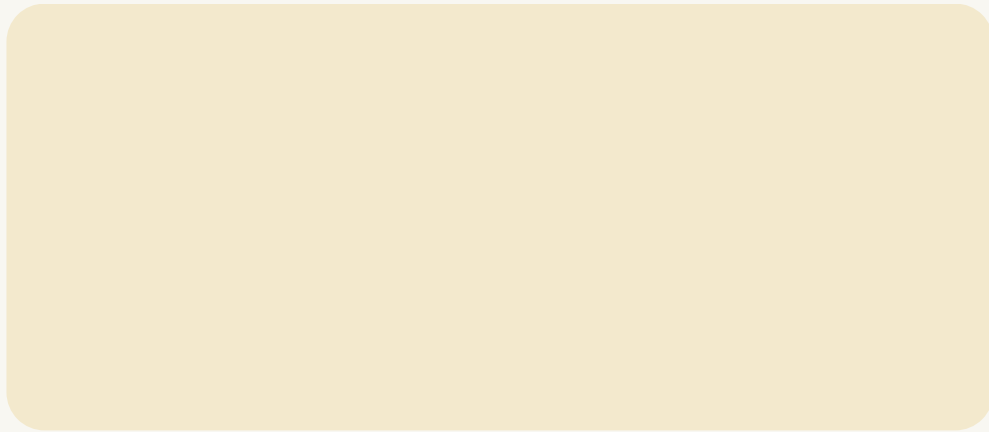
In my experience, taking time to reflect on the sorts of things we've covered thus far can leave you feeling a bit down. And that's why we aren't done yet. We don't want to be women who are delusional about our sinful, fleshly proclivities, so the work you've done so far in this workbook is crucial. Now, we shift into stepping forward boldly into what is next. As you are walking with Jesus, you don't need to despair that you will miss what He has for you. Simply trust and obey, as the old hymn says. Seek Him and ask for wisdom and discernment. It sounds like the most basic thing in the world to ask God for wisdom, but believe me when I say that taking everything to God in prayer will transform your life. So if you don't have the clarity, simply ask for it and do the next thing.

Fear not tomorrows, child of the king. trust them
with Jesus. Do the next thing.
Do it immediately. Do it with prayer.
Do it reliantly, casting all care.
Do it with reverence, tracing Christ's hand.
He placed it before you with earnest command.
Rest on his omnipotence, safe beneath his wing.
Leave all resultings. Do the next thing.

Elisabeth Elliot

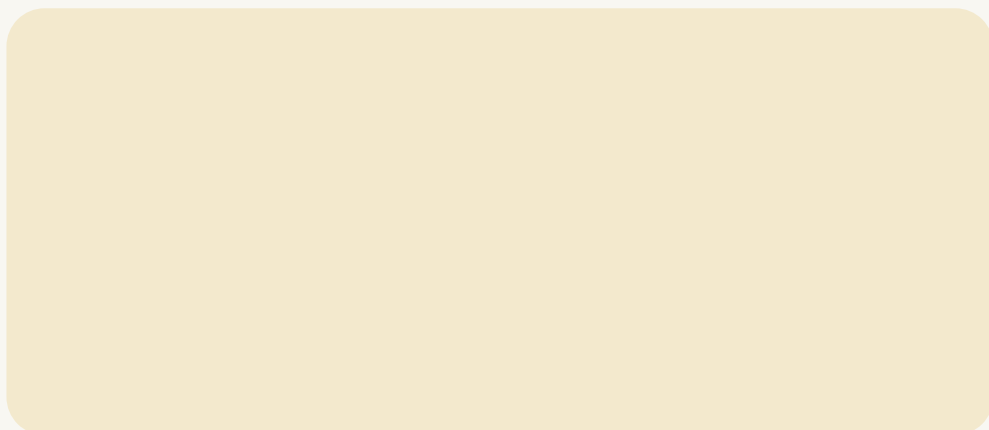
REFLECTION 1.

Take some time to consider what responsibilities and obligations exist in your life, as well as areas you have wanted to give more of yourself to, or nudges you've been feeling and perhaps shoving down. As things come up for you, these could be some of your "next things" as Elisabeth Elliot so beautifully writes about. Following Jesus faithfully is made up of countless moments and decisions every day, most of them going unnoticed by others. But God, in His omnipotence sees you. Do all things with excellence unto His glory, and in this way, even the smallest "next thing" that you do is significant. Reflect on this below.



REFLECTION 2.

Now, getting practical, think about what needs to happen in order for you to move forward into your "next thing". There may be people you need to loop in, changes you need to make to your schedule, a risk you need to take, etc. There also may be things present that could hinder you from what you are committing to. Be mindful of what may thwart you from walking out your convictions with confidence. Take some time to reflect on these things below.



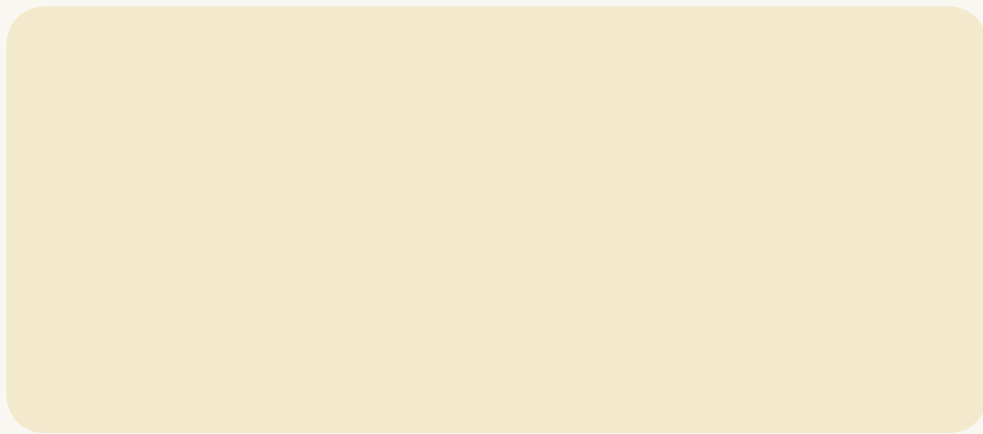
EMBRACE AND RELEASE

When you look at Elisabeth Elliot's life (and if you haven't, I can't encourage you enough to) you will see that she lived a remarkable life that was made up of a whole lot of patient waiting, faithful perseverance, and bold trust. Her ability to do the next right thing didn't come because God sent sign after sign and supernaturally told her what to do. Elisabeth was a woman who read her Bible, asked God for what she needed and waited upon His timing (the frustrating part being that we just can't know that information ahead of time).

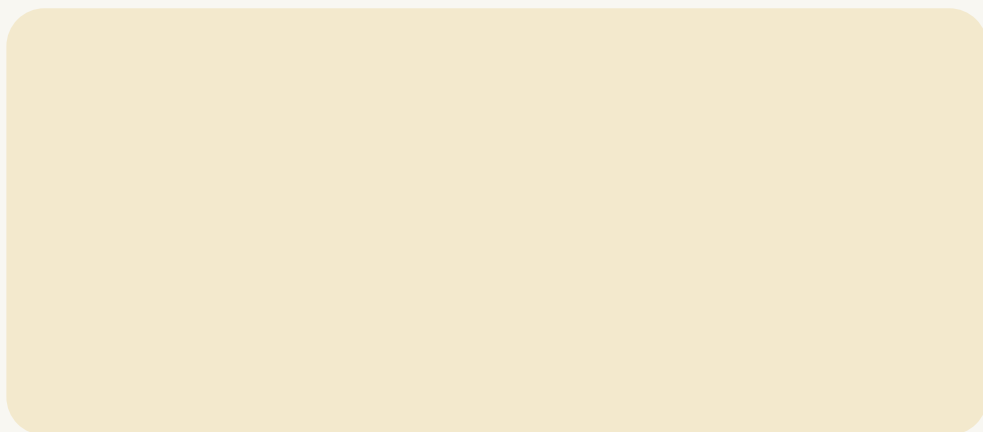
So, my encouragement to you is to not despair if you don't feel strongly attached to your "next thing", or if you feel a lack of clarity. Simply ask God to show you, and be open to what He says. It could be something mundane and seemingly boring. But you are being shaped in those moments and there is nothing mundane or boring about being shaped more into the likeness of Christ, and becoming more of the woman He desires you to be.

Take some time to reflect on what stepping into your "next thing" may look like from here. And if there is something you fear may tempt you to hold back, reflect on that as well.

I'M EMBRACING....



I'M RELEASING...

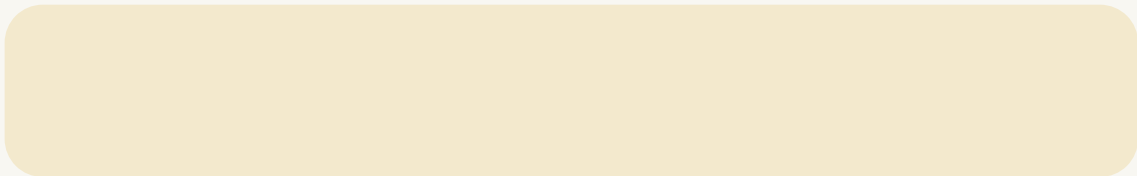


MY ALIGNMENT SUMMARY

Our final reflections are below, and I invite you to take your time with them (or maybe after all the work you've put in, the answers will come to you quickly). You can easily refer back to this section when things feel cloudy, you're beginning to feel unstable, or you're fearful of a next step. Whatever it may be for you, let the words you write below become a sort of personal mantra you can hold onto.

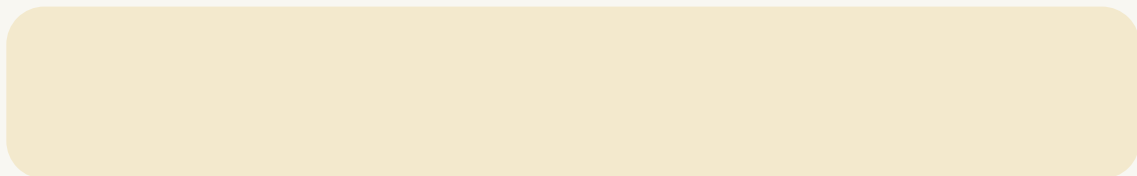
ROOT:

Name the area where your roots are deep, and conversely where your roots need to be watered. What steps will you take (simply praying is a step!) to carry growth forward in these areas?



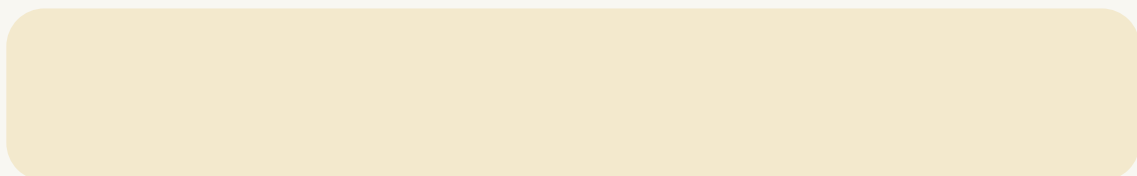
REALIGN

Identify the areas where your choices and actions don't align with your values in the way you believe they should. Similarly, what areas tempt you to drift away from holiness?



RISE

What promptings have stirred in your heart regarding your "next thing"? What do you need to do to step into that, whether it's proactively seeking out something new, or discarding a hindrance?



A NOTE OF THANKS AND ENCOURAGEMENT

I want to thank you from the bottom of my heart for investing your time and energy into this workbook. My prayer is that it is a tool that helps you live wisely. I hope you can come back to it when you feel lost or shaken, and be reminded that God created you wonderfully, He has a purpose for you, and often it is the simple steps of obedience in our ordinary days that allows us to live a purposeful life.

AN INVITATION

The work you've started here doesn't end here. Maybe continuing the work for you means bringing in some of your friends or trusted mentors to continue to digest what you've learned and to support you as you walk out your convictions.

I also want to invite you in utilizing me as as part of your support. This can look like working directly with me 1:1 where we can go more in-depth with what came up for you and what you are specifically navigating.

I also have a Coaching Group for College Women coming up. This will be a great opportunity to continue this deep work with guidance from me, and support from peers. Click the link below to join the waitlist.

A handwritten signature in black ink. It begins with a heart symbol, followed by the name "Rachel" in a cursive script.